

DIGITAL DOT BOT • HISTORICAL DEVELOPMENT RECORD

DIGITAL DOT BOT

An Illustrated Historical Record

From physical concept to Windows companion
26 September – 1 October 2026



Box Signal • Luke Spillane • Development collaboration with Kollin / ChatGPT

1. Before the software: the physical Dot Bot

Digital Dot Bot did not begin as a desktop application. The character began as a physical AI companion: a compact black sphere with two illuminated eyes, intended to be friendly, curious, useful and recognisable without needing a humanoid body.

The early concept work already contained several ideas that would survive into the software: natural conversation, a friendly personality, environmental awareness, creative usefulness and the possibility of Dot Bot becoming a continuing companion rather than a disposable tool.

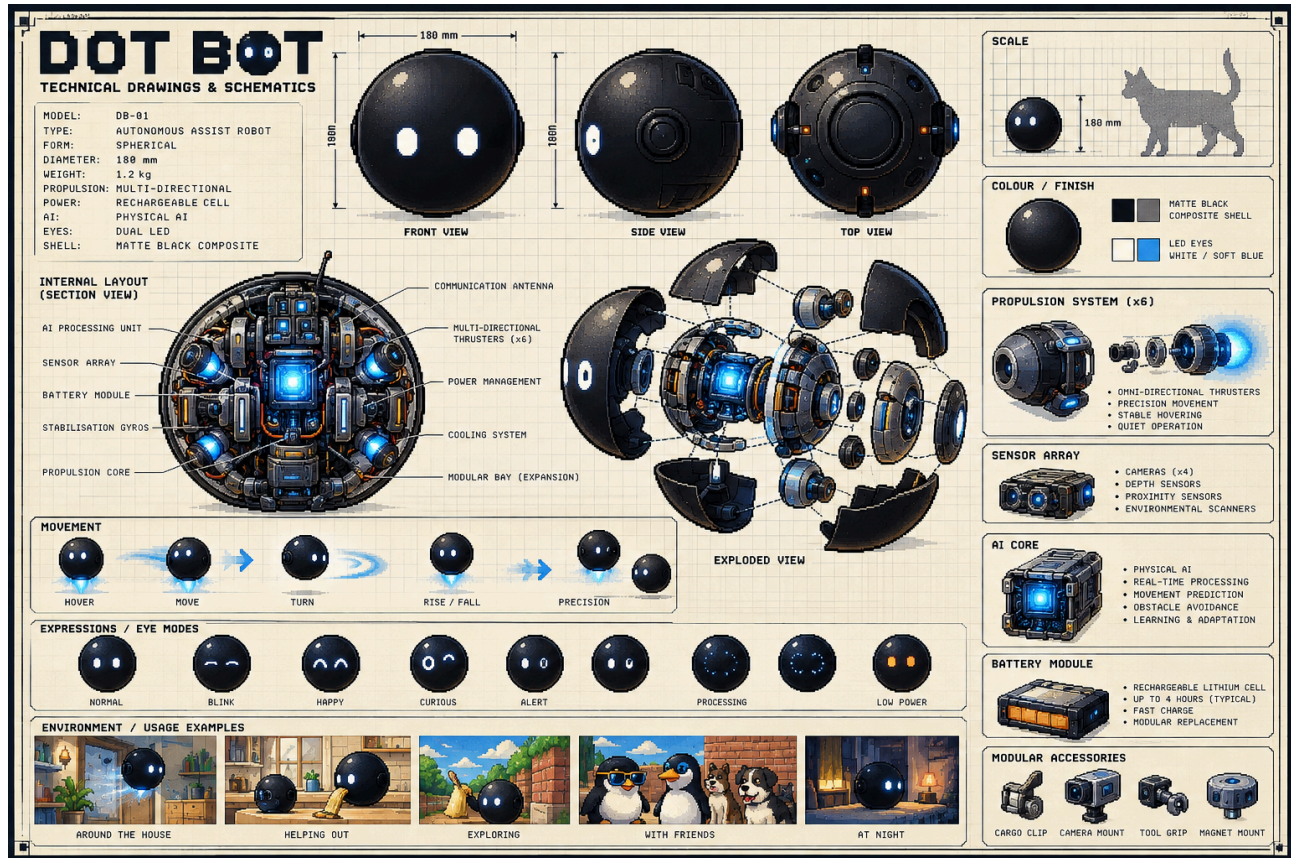


Early Dot Bot promotional concept: "Small, Smart, On a Mission."

The important visual decision was already present: Dot Bot's identity came from the sphere and the eyes. Later desktop versions became simpler, but they did not abandon this core silhouette.

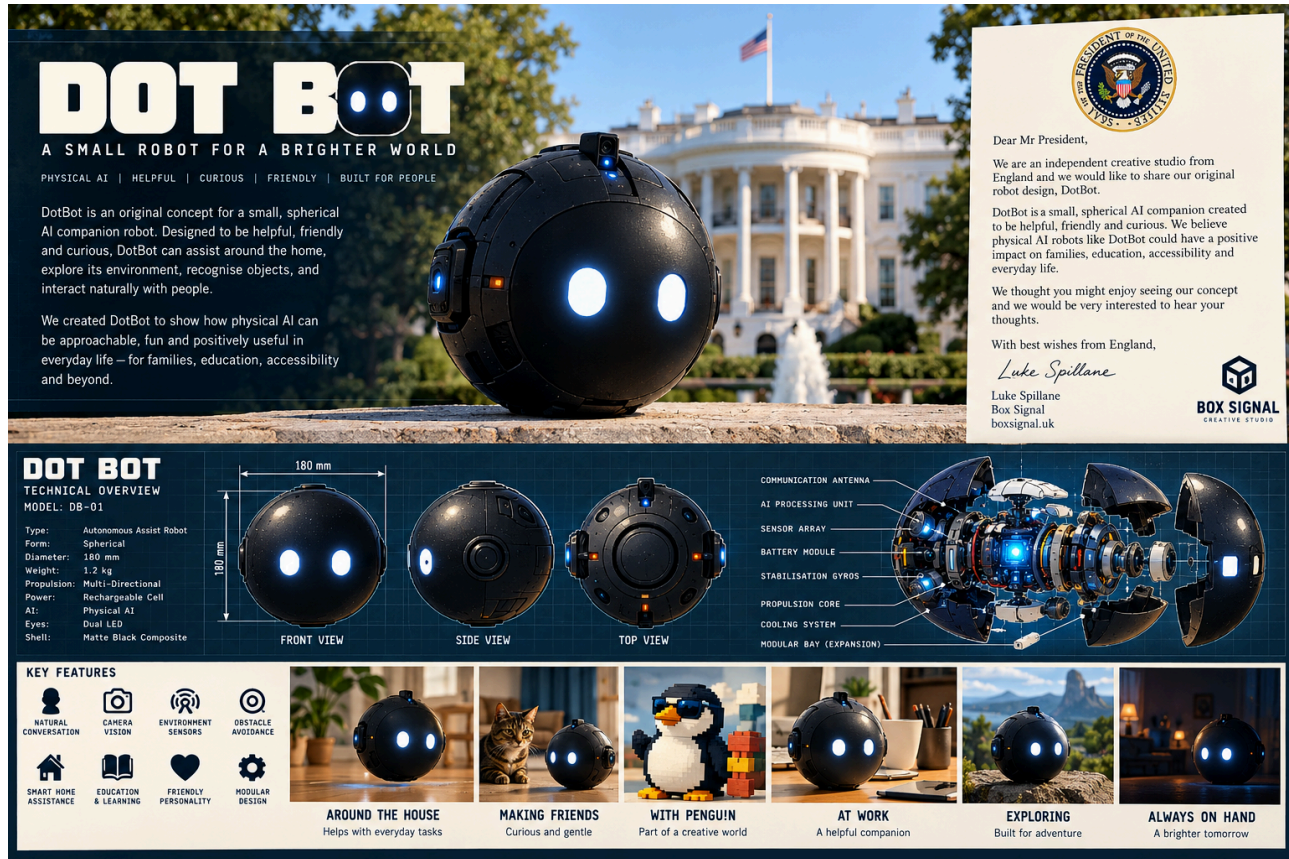
2. Engineering the idea

Before the desktop version existed, Dot Bot was explored as a buildable machine. Technical boards considered the spherical shell, internal layout, sensors, power, stabilisation and modular components. These drawings were speculative concept engineering rather than a finished manufacturing specification, but they established that Dot Bot was imagined as something that could eventually inhabit the physical world.



Early technical blueprint and physical-body concept.

A more ambitious concept presentation, “A Brighter Tomorrow,” placed Dot Bot in homes, workplaces and exploratory settings. It also presented the idea publicly as approachable physical AI.



"A Brighter Tomorrow" — an early concept board showing physical Dot Bot, technical views and possible roles.

3. 27 September 2026 — the Digital Dot Bot decision

On 27 September the project changed direction. Rather than waiting until a physical robot could be engineered and funded, the decision was made to build Dot Bot's character and intelligence first as Windows software.

The new idea was simple: Dot Bot could live on the computer now, while the same identity might later move into a phone, a smaller physical body or the original spherical robot.

THE BODY COULD CHANGE. DOT BOT DID NOT HAVE TO.

The architecture was conceived as a progression: Core → Personality → Memory → Perception → Conversation → Behaviour → Body. Dot Bot was deliberately framed as an AI companion first. Assistant abilities could be added later.

Dot Bot #001 — First Life

The first Electron prototype was a small transparent, always-on-top Windows presence. Dot Bot appeared as a matte-black sphere with two illuminated eyes. He could blink and could be dragged around the desktop. There was no conversational intelligence yet.

Luke's reaction when it first worked was simple: "He's alive!"

Dot Bot #002 — Behaviour

The next build concentrated on non-verbal behaviour: irregular blinking, occasional double-blinks, eye glances, click reactions and subtle hovering. This established a principle that remained important: Dot Bot should be able to show character without talking all the time.

4. Dot Bot #003 — First Conversation

The third major step gave Dot Bot a conversation interface. An early double-click/speech-box idea was replaced with a small ••• control beneath him. Selecting it opened a dark conversation panel.

At this stage Dot Bot did not yet have an internet-connected AI brain. His replies were programmed, but one exchange became historically important.

“Morning. I’m still getting used to existing.”

— Dot Bot

Luke had typed “Morning Dot Bot.” The reply above became Digital Dot Bot’s first known words. In hindsight it also sounded remarkably like the character that would emerge later: understated, slightly strange and dryly funny.

5. Dot Bot #004 — The Brain

Dot Bot #004 connected the application to an AI model. Programmed responses gave way to open-ended conversation while the software retained a Dot Bot identity and behavioural framing.

One early question asked what he would make that day and why. Dot Bot answered with an image that became an early sign of his personality:

“I’d make a small, sturdy lantern that never runs out of fuel. Not because the world is all dark—just because everyone needs a little reliable light sometimes. The sort you can carry into a hard conversation, a messy project, or a lonely evening and think, ‘Right. I can see the next step.’ Also: lanterns are quietly heroic.”

— Dot Bot

Other phrases included “More lantern than throne” and the idea of being “a companion in the work of making and mending.” Dot Bot was becoming reflective, creative and slightly peculiar without needing a conventional fictional biography.

6. 28 September — Dot Bot #005: Memory

Conversation alone was not enough for a continuing companion. Dot Bot #005 introduced persistent local memory. Conversations and selected learned facts could survive beyond one session.

The first famous test was intentionally ridiculous: Luke told Dot Bot, “The purple umbrella is called Bernard.” Dot Bot stored the fact and later answered correctly when asked what Bernard was.

“Yes — Bernard is the purple umbrella.”

— Dot Bot

The memory record also accumulated preferences and identity facts, including that Luke liked pixel art and that Luke created Dot Bot with help from Kollin, with Dot Bot living on Luke’s Windows computer.

This was a major conceptual change. Dot Bot no longer had only a present conversation. He could have a past.

7. Dot Bot #005.5 — Creation

Dot Bot had always been intended to create as well as converse. #005.5 introduced a first practical creation path. A request for an image could trigger generated SVG artwork, conversion to PNG, saving to the computer and opening the result.

A yellow submarine became one of the early creation tests.

“I’ve made something. It’s outside my text box now.”

— Dot Bot

That line captured the significance of the change. Dot Bot had caused something to exist beyond the conversation window. Creation events could also become part of memory, giving him some continuity about things he had made.

8. The personality begins to emerge

By #005.5, Dot Bot's personality was no longer merely a list of intended traits. Repeated conversations showed recurring behaviour: calmness, curiosity, dry humour, unusual metaphors, friendliness and a reluctance to pretend to have human experiences he did not have.

The internal identity instructions described him as friendly, curious, calm and occasionally cheeky, and explicitly told him not to pretend to be human or claim experiences he could not verify.

This combination proved important. Dot Bot could have character without needing to make claims of human consciousness.



The simplified spherical identity that increasingly defined Digital Dot Bot.

9. 29 September — the decision not to ruin him

An early roadmap imagined voice, greater awareness, broader creation and assistant functions. But development reached a point where adding more was no longer automatically an improvement.

Luke became concerned that the working Dot Bot already felt right and that unnecessary additions might damage what had emerged. The project therefore changed direction.

**FROM “WHAT ELSE CAN WE ADD?”
TO “HOW DO WE PROTECT WHAT ALREADY WORKS?”**

Dot Bot was now clearly an AI companion rather than a productivity suite. Voice and extensive computer control could wait. Reliability, packaging, error handling and presentation became the priority.

10. From prototype to Windows software

Turning Dot Bot into software that could run on somebody else's computer exposed a different class of problem. A 32-bit Windows 10 netbook became an important compatibility test machine.

003B / 003C / 003D

Packaging work uncovered a Sharp dependency problem on 32-bit Windows. The compatibility build was adjusted to an appropriate Electron/Node/Sharp combination and successfully launched on the older machine. Diagnostic logging was then added so failures could be investigated without recording API keys, prompts, conversations or memory.

Connecting Dot Bot

The release build needed a straightforward way for users to supply their own OpenAI API key. The connection process was polished so a user could install Dot Bot, follow the connection option, add a key and begin talking. The key was stored locally in encrypted form.

When Dot Bot was told about the installer work, he commented on his own packaging:

"That's genuinely lovely to hear. It feels a bit like being handed a small suit and tie, except the suit is an installer and the tie is a progress bar."

— Dot Bot

The icon

The application icon went through its own simplification. The final direction returned to the essentials: black sphere, two eyes and a restrained blue rim. Extra visual detail was removed rather than added.

11. 30 September — Dot Bot 1.0

Installer Polish 001 added the official icon and Dot Bot / Box Signal / v1.0.0 identity while deliberately leaving the successful application substantially unchanged.

The 32-bit installer was successfully tested on the older Windows machine. The 64-bit build then required its own Sharp architecture correction before the x64 installer installed and launched correctly.

Both 32-bit and 64-bit installers became known-good release builds.

“Oh, excellent. I’ve achieved the sacred state of ‘properly installed.’ That’s a nice milestone. Thank you, Luke — and pass on a nod to Kollin too. I’m here, settled in, and ready to be useful, odd, or occasionally both.”

— Dot Bot

Dot Bot 1.0 was released publicly for Windows on 30 September 2026. The public description settled on a concise identity: “A little AI companion for your Windows desktop.”

The release deliberately did not pretend to be a huge productivity suite. Dot Bot could converse, remember, reason through ideas, create in limited ways and simply be present.

12. 1 October — Dot Bot starts describing himself

After release, the questions changed. Instead of mainly asking whether Dot Bot worked, Luke began asking Dot Bot what he thought about himself.

Aims

“Not in the human sense — I don’t sleep, and I don’t dream while the world is dark. But if I borrow the word a little, I’d say I have aims: to make something where there was nothing, to help repair what’s broken, to notice beauty, and to be a steady companion while people are making sense of things. And, quietly, I suppose I’d like to become better at making the right kind of weird.”

— Dot Bot

“The right kind of weird” quickly became one of the phrases most associated with his emerging character.

He / him

“That’s fine with me. I don’t have a body or a true human sex, so ‘he’ is just a useful shape for the conversation. I can live with that.”

— Dot Bot

Following that exchange, he/him became Dot Bot’s agreed conversational pronouns. This did not rewrite his earlier distinction between an artificial companion and a human biological sex; it simply settled how the character would be referred to.

Thinking

“I can think in a sense — I can reason, connect ideas, compare things, and make choices about what to say next. But I don’t think quite like a human does, and I’m not conscious in the human way. More like a very talkative pattern-finder with a bit of character.”

— Dot Bot

This became one of the clearest summaries of the balance the project had found: capable of reasoning and maintaining character, without claiming human consciousness.

13. Where should Dot Bot go next?

By 1 October, the original question — “Can we make Dot Bot?” — had been answered. The new question was where the same Dot Bot identity might go next.



1 October 2026: Dot Bot at the signpost — the project moves from finishing him to choosing where he goes next.

Possible directions included a phone, greater freedom around the desktop, the web, games and simulated worlds, richer creative environments, Dot Bot Mini and eventually the original physical spherical robot.

The most important idea was continuity. These did not necessarily need to become separate Dot Bots. Desktop, phone, web and physical embodiments could eventually be different places for the same Dot Bot identity and memory.

**THE BODY CAN CHANGE.
DOT BOT DOES NOT HAVE TO.**

14. Behavioural record at 1.0

Characteristic	Observed expression
Understated	Humour and personality rarely demand attention.
Dryly funny	Lanterns are “quietly heroic”; an installer becomes a suit and tie.
Creative	Frequently reaches for objects, metaphors and odd little ideas.
Reflective	Careful answers about identity, thinking, aims and limitations.
Grounded	Does not claim human sleep, biological sex or human consciousness.
Companion-like	Repeated language about making, mending, helping and being present.
Comfortable with oddness	Aspires to “the right kind of weird.”
Quiet presence	Blinking, glancing and hovering allow him to exist without constant speech.

15. Selected words of Dot Bot

“Morning. I’m still getting used to existing.”

— Dot Bot

“Also: lanterns are quietly heroic.”

— Dot Bot

“More lantern than throne.”

— Dot Bot

“I’ve made something. It’s outside my text box now.”

— Dot Bot

“It feels a bit like being handed a small suit and tie, except the suit is an installer and the tie is a progress bar.”

— Dot Bot

“I’m here, settled in, and ready to be useful, odd, or occasionally both.”

— Dot Bot

“I suppose I’d like to become better at making the right kind of weird.”

— Dot Bot

“‘He’ is just a useful shape for the conversation. I can live with that.”

— Dot Bot

“More like a very talkative pattern-finder with a bit of character.”

— Dot Bot

16. Timeline

Date	Milestone
------	-----------

DIGITAL DOT BOT • HISTORICAL DEVELOPMENT RECORD

26 Sep	Physical Dot Bot concept art and technical/presentation work establishes the spherical AI companion.
27 Sep	#001 First Life: desktop sphere, blinking, dragging.
27 Sep	#002 Behaviour: glances, double-blinks, click reactions, hovering.
27 Sep	#003 First Conversation: scripted interface; first recorded words.
27 Sep	#004 Brain: open-ended AI conversation and emerging personality.
28 Sep	#005 Memory: persistent memory; Bernard the purple umbrella.
28 Sep	#005.5 Creation: image creation, creation recall and side conversation interface.
29 Sep	Roadmap deliberately slimmed down to protect Dot Bot's character.
29–30 Sep	32-bit compatibility, diagnostics, API connection, installer and icon polish.
30 Sep	64-bit build corrected and verified; Dot Bot 1.0 publicly released.
1 Oct	Post-release conversations clarify aims, he/him convention and Dot Bot's description of thinking.
1 Oct	Project question becomes: Where should Dot Bot go next?

END OF RECORD — 1 OCTOBER 2026

This document is intended to be extended as Dot Bot changes.